

50TH ANNIVERSARY

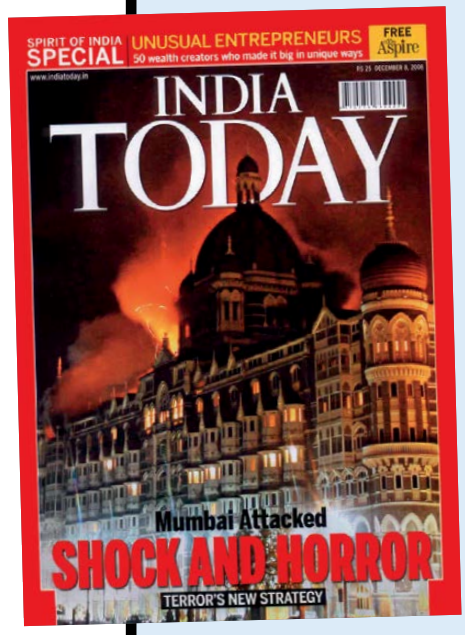
TERROR
2005-2015

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The period saw India endure what can only be described as a prolonged season of terror. It was not a single war with a single enemy, but a grinding, multi-front assault that struck cities, markets, trains, hotels and forests with ruthless regularity. It tested the resilience of the Indian state and exposed the limits of its security imagination.

On October 29, 2005, serial bomb blasts ripped through Delhi's crowded markets in Paharganj and Sarojini Nagar and inside a DTC bus, killing more than 60 people just days before Diwali. Less than a year later came the Mumbai train bombings of July 11, 2006. Seven coordinated explosions tore through first-class compartments of suburban trains during the evening rush hour, killing 187 commuters. The investigation later revealed a meticulously planned operation involving Lashkar-e-Taiba operatives, sleeper cells, hawala funding and improvised explosive devices built from pressure cookers packed with RDX and ammonium nitrate. As these attacks multiplied across Jaipur, Hyderabad, Varanasi, Malegaon and Ahmedabad, a pattern emerged. Terror groups were deliberately choosing crowded, everyday spaces and using low-cost, hard-to-detect devices. Intelligence failures were routine. Centre-state coordination was weak. Each attack followed the same cycle of outrage, blame and forgetfulness.

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Mumbai Attacked: Shock and Horror, *Dec. 8, 2008*

❝Just as 9/11 entered the dictionary of terror, so too will 26/11, the day which will go down as Mumbai's darkest hour, when terrorists laid siege to the city's roads, airports, railway station, hospitals and two of its best-known luxury hotels, leaving a trail of death and destruction and taking hostages. The scenes were devastating: explosions, raging fires, dead bodies, heavily armed terrorists with rucksacks containing grenades and explosives and firing indiscriminately at people on the streets, and a metropolis on its knees. The most heart-rending sight was Mumbai's most iconic and beautiful building, the 106-year-old heritage wing of the Taj Mahal Hotel, reduced to a blackened ruin.❞